A Christian Conversation Guide for LDS Friends

The Belief Files

Sharing the gospel with clarity and respect

Beyond the Message | November 8, 2026

The purpose of this guide

This guide helps a Christian talk with a Latter-day Saint friend, relative, neighbor, or missionary about Jesus Christ and salvation. The aim is to understand the person, explain the gospel clearly, examine real differences honestly, and offer an invitation that the other person is free to consider.

The perspective here is evangelical and Trinitarian Christian. Latter-day Saints identify as Christians and affirm Jesus Christ, His atonement, and His resurrection. Their Church also distinguishes its beliefs from historic Christian creeds and accepts additional scripture. Recognize that self-description before discussing the differences. Asking what someone means by a familiar word often opens a better conversation than announcing that the person has used it wrongly. [3, 6]

The central question is larger than whether Joseph Smith made a particular claim. It is who Jesus is, what He accomplished, and how a sinner is reconciled to God. The twelve case files can help investigate historical questions. They support this conversation; they do not replace the positive Christian account of Christ.

The manner belongs to the message

First Peter 3:15 joins giving a reason for Christian hope with “meekness and fear.” Second Timothy 2:24 says that the Lord's servant must be “gentle unto all men, apt to teach, patient.” These instructions govern the conversation when disagreement becomes difficult, not just its opening tone. Read those passages in their surrounding paragraphs. [1, 2]

Pray for wisdom and love. Review the gospel before reviewing objections. Be ready to say, “I do not know; let me check.” Speak about what a source actually says. Acknowledge your own sins and failures without using them to avoid a question about truth.

A friendship should remain sincere if the person declines a religious discussion. Do not conceal a conversion agenda inside a favor, pretend to be considering LDS membership to obtain a meeting, or make continuing kindness depend on agreement. A clear invitation can be direct and still leave room for an honest no.

A simple first conversation

You do not need to cover twelve investigations in one meeting. A useful first conversation can begin with five moves, at whatever pace the relationship permits:

1. **Ask.** “My faith in Jesus matters deeply to me. Would you be open to talking about what we each believe He has done for us?”
2. **Listen.** “What does your relationship with Jesus mean to you?” Let the answer finish.
3. **Clarify.** “When you say salvation, what do you mean?” Reflect the answer and invite correction.
4. **Read.** With permission, open one passage together, such as Ephesians 2:1–10. Ask what the passage says before bringing in other arguments.
5. **Invite.** “Would you like to keep reading this together another time?” Accept the answer without pressing for an immediate commitment.

If only one thing happens, let it be accurate understanding. You can leave a conversation with a clear difference still unresolved and a good reason to meet again.

Begin with the person

A lifelong member, a recent convert, a questioning member, and a missionary may approach the same question differently. Ask the person rather than assuming a Church document describes every detail of their present understanding.

With a friend: “What has your faith meant in your life? Is there a question you wish other Christians would ask before telling you what they think?”

With a relative: “I care about our relationship. I would like us to understand each other's faith more clearly. Would this be a comfortable time to talk?” Choose privacy when appropriate. Do not turn a family gathering into an unexpected public debate.

With visiting missionaries: “I am a Christian, and I am not seeking membership in your Church. I would welcome an honest conversation about Jesus and grace. Could we read a passage together and each explain how we understand it?” Be equally clear if you are considering membership. Respect the visitors' time and their freedom to end the meeting.

The LDS Church's own sharing guidance encourages listening, care, and invitations. That provides a useful point of contact; it does not establish how any particular missionary or member will respond. [14]

Listen and reflect before answering

Choose one or two questions rather than working through an interview:

- What first led you to trust what your Church teaches?
- What do you believe Jesus has accomplished for you?
- When you speak of being saved, what are you being saved from?
- How do you understand forgiveness and confidence before God?

- How do you decide whether a teaching comes from God?
- What would you most like me to understand about your beliefs?

Then reflect: “If I heard you correctly, you believe ____. Have I understood?” Do not add a hostile conclusion to the summary. If the person says, “That is not what I mean,” invite them to restate it.

Listen for the actual question. Someone grieving a loved one may need compassion before a comparison of temple teachings. Someone asking about an ancient manuscript may want a source, not an account of your personal experience. Ask whether they want to explore the question now.

Belief can be connected with family, community, and identity. Do not promise that changing religious convictions will be socially easy. Offer steady friendship, respect the person's privacy, and let them decide whom to involve in further discussion.

Clarify the words you share

Shared vocabulary can conceal different meanings. This table supplies starting questions, not a test with predetermined answers. Let the person answer in their own words.

Shared word	A useful question	Read together
Jesus	Who is Jesus, and how does He relate to everything God created?	John 1:1–18; Colossians 1:15–20
God	How do you understand the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit?	Matthew 28:19; John 1; John 17
Grace	What is freely given through Christ, and how do faith, obedience, and ordinances relate to it?	Ephesians 2:1–10; Titus 3:3–7
Saved	Do you mean resurrection, forgiveness, eternal life, or exaltation?	Romans 4:1–8; 5:1–11; John 5:24
Authority	How would we test a claimed revelation or a teaching from a prophet?	Acts 17:10–12; Galatians 1:6–9; 1 John 4:1–6

The questions about salvation reflect distinctions in the Church's own overview. It describes several senses, including resurrection for all, salvation from sin connected with faithfulness and authorized ordinances, and exaltation. Ask which sense is intended before comparing it with a biblical passage. Do not treat an answer about universal resurrection as if it answered a question about forgiveness or final acceptance before God. [5]

Explain the differences carefully

Jesus and the nature of God

The Christian position presented here confesses one eternal God: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, distinct persons. The Son is eternally divine and became human. This is neither three gods nor one person merely appearing under three names. It is a theological account drawn from reading the biblical texts together, not a definition established by a single isolated verse.

In John 1, ask who the Word is, what existed in the beginning, what came into being through Him, and what it means that the Word became flesh. In Colossians 1, read the descriptions of Christ together, including “firstborn” and His relation to all created things. Explain why you understand the Son as the uncreated Creator. Invite the LDS interpretation of those same passages. Avoid opening with a slogan about a “different Jesus” in place of this explanation. [7]

Grace, obedience, and assurance

The LDS grace study guide says grace is freely given and cannot be earned. It also describes coming to Christ through faith, repentance, baptism, receiving the Holy Ghost, and obedience. Do not represent this as belief in salvation without Christ, or claim that Latter-day Saints never teach grace. [4]

The question to explore is how Christ's work, faith, ordinances, and continuing obedience relate to forgiveness and final acceptance. The evangelical understanding here is that justification is God's gift received through faith in Christ; good works follow as the fruit of living faith. Ask your friend to explain their understanding before comparing it with that account. [8–10]

Confidence in Christ does not mean moral indifference. Christians should confess sin, repent, and grow in obedience. Nor should you diagnose an individual's spiritual condition from a label. Explain the ground of your hope and allow the person to examine it in Scripture.

Scripture and a claimed restoration

LDS Articles of Faith affirm additional scripture, continuing revelation, and authority to administer ordinances. They qualify their affirmation of the Bible by reference to correct translation. Ask how a claimed revelation should be evaluated and what could count against it. Explain your own standards and welcome the same scrutiny of Christian claims. [6, 12]

Do not move from “we read the Bible differently” to “you refuse to read it.” A productive question is: “Could we first follow this author's argument, then compare our interpretations and explain why each of us finds one stronger?”

Share the gospel plainly

Ask permission: “May I explain why I am placing my trust in Jesus? Then I would like to hear where you agree or disagree.” Here is one way to put it in ordinary language:

“God made us, and we are accountable to Him. All of us have sinned; I cannot make myself right with Him by building a better record. Jesus Christ, God's eternal Son, became human, lived without sin, died for our sins, and rose again. My hope rests in what He has accomplished. I understand forgiveness and acceptance before God as a gift of grace, received through faith in Christ. Repentance means turning from sin toward God, and faith means relying on Christ rather than presenting my own worthiness as my claim. Good works matter because God changes those He saves. Christ's saving work is sufficient; obedience is the fruit of the new life He gives. I want to follow Him because I belong to Him. That is why I invite you to look closely at Jesus and the promises of the gospel.” [7–11]

This is the guide's evangelical explanation. Other Christian traditions describe some relationships among faith, baptism, justification, and sanctification differently. Name the position you are explaining rather than attributing every formulation here to every Christian church.

Your personal story can show why this matters: what you trusted, what you came to understand about Jesus, and how that changed your life. Keep it

truthful. Changed feelings or improved circumstances are not, by themselves, proof that an entire religious system is true.

Read a passage rather than trade slogans

Ephesians 2:8–10 says in the KJV: “For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast. For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works, which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them.” Read verses 1–10 together so that human need, God's mercy, salvation, and the resulting life remain connected. [8]

Ask: Who acts to give life? What grounds are excluded for boasting? What is the place of good works in verse 10? Then explain why you see works as the result of salvation rather than its purchase price. Invite the other person's reading and examine the disagreement, if one remains.

Romans 4:1–8 and James 2:14–26 belong in the conversation together. This guide reads Paul as excluding works as the basis of justification and James as rejecting a claim to faith that produces no faithful action. That is an interpretation to explain from context, not a reason to brush James aside. Ask what kind of faith James is challenging and what each writer is addressing. [9, 10]

First Corinthians 15:1–8 supplies the gospel's historical center: Christ's death for sins, burial, resurrection, and reported appearances. Paul reports an appearance to more than five hundred people; the passage is not five hundred separately preserved written testimonies. Present the Christian evidence with the same care you ask of LDS evidence. [11]

Work through common questions

We already believe in Jesus

“I recognize that Jesus is central to what you believe. I would like to understand who you believe He is and what His work accomplishes. Could we each explain that and read John 1 together?” Affirm an actual agreement without assuming every doctrinal conclusion is shared. [3, 7]

If the person thinks your account misrepresents theirs, ask them to correct it before continuing. The point is to identify the disagreement accurately, including a disagreement about authority or salvation that may remain after both people affirm Christ's resurrection.

Faith without works is dead

“I agree that James rejects a lifeless profession. I do not believe following Jesus makes obedience optional. My question is how obedience relates to being accepted by God. Could we read James 2 alongside Romans 4 and Ephesians 2?” [8–10]

Avoid saying “works do not matter.” Ask whether you are discussing the basis of acceptance, evidence of faith, growth in holiness, or final judgment. Those are related questions, but exchanging the same word across them can conceal the issue.

What about baptism

“Baptism matters, and I want to take passages about it seriously. Could we read Acts 2:37–41 and Romans 6:1–14 in context, then discuss how you understand baptism, faith, and forgiveness?” [13]

The evangelical account in this guide does not make an LDS priesthood ordinance the ground of justification. Christians differ over baptism's mode, recipients, and relation to salvation. Do not pretend those differences do not exist, or dismiss a difficult verse because it complicates your presentation. If asked about another passage, such as 1 Peter 3:21, read its context and return with a considered answer.

I have a spiritual testimony

“I do not doubt that your experience matters to you. I also have experiences I take seriously. How should we evaluate experiences when sincere people draw conflicting conclusions from them?”

First John 4:1–6 tests claimed spiritual teaching in relation to Christ. Acts 17:10–12 describes examining the Scriptures. Discuss how testimony, textual claims, and public evidence relate. Do not mock an experience, declare that a feeling proves a whole system, or diagnose its spiritual cause without grounds. Apply your standard to your own experiences too. [12]

The Bible has been changed

“Which passage or teaching concerns you? Are we talking about a translation choice, a difference among manuscripts, or a claim that the gospel itself was lost?” These are different claims and require different evidence.

Ask to examine a specific example. Compare the text, the source for the objection, and serious explanations. Do not invent a statistic about manuscript agreement or say no textual questions exist. If the issue requires knowledge you do not have, arrange to research it. Your honesty can model the careful inquiry you are inviting. [6]

We need a living prophet

“I understand why present guidance would matter. How would we distinguish a true claim to speak for God from a mistaken one? Could a prophet's teaching be tested, and what standard would we use?”

Read Galatians 1:6–9 and discuss its warning about a contrary gospel. A Christian still needs to explain why a particular teaching conflicts with the apostolic message; simply applying the label “false prophet” does not supply that argument. If a historical claim is central, choose the relevant case file and examine its sources together. [6, 12, 15]

Christians have done terrible things too

“That is true, and Christian wrongdoing deserves honest examination. I should not excuse abuse or racism because the people responsible used a Christian name. Which event or teaching do you want to discuss?”

Use the same distinction between a person's conduct, an institution's actions, a teaching, and its claimed divine authority that you use in the LDS investigations. Acknowledging Christian failures does not settle every theological question. It does make clear that your standards apply to your own community.

This feels like an attack on my family

“Thank you for telling me. I care about you and your family. What have I said that felt unfair or inaccurate? We can slow down or stop.” Correct a misstatement plainly. If your approach was hurtful, apologize for it without attaching an immediate new argument.

If the person says they do not want to discuss religion, honor that request. Do not recast a refusal as permission for one last objection. Continue ordinary friendship without turning every later contact into another attempt.

Use the investigations when they answer a real question

Begin with the question the person wants to consider. Ask whether they would like to look at a relevant document. Share the source rather than asking them to accept a summary on your authority.

Question raised	Case files	A useful focus
What do the vision accounts establish?	001 The First Vision	Date, author, audience, and what each account reports.
What does translation mean in these claims?	002 Translation; 003 Abraham	Manuscripts, surviving artifacts, testimony, and missing evidence.
What is taught about God's nature and human destiny?	004 Becoming Like God; 007 Mother in Heaven	Early sources, later descriptions, and the biblical comparison.
What can ancestry research establish?	005 DNA	The actual claim and the scope and limits of genetic evidence.
How is restored authority understood?	006 Priesthood, Temples, and Women	Early records, later recollections, and changing practice.
How should institutional wrongdoing be assessed?	008 Peace and Violence	Responsibility, evidence, competing explanations, and acknowledgment.
What changed in plural marriage?	009–011 Plural Marriage and the Manifesto	Different settings, women's accounts, dates, and kinds of change.
How did racial restrictions relate to authority?	012 Race and the Priesthood	Members' records, the restrictions, explanations, and the 1978 change.

These are pointers to completed investigations, not fresh historical findings. Read each file's qualifications and source register. Case 001 is on the website; Cases 002–012 are available in the app. [15]

Keep evidence and conclusions distinct

Work through one claim: What is alleged? What is the earliest relevant source? Who recorded it, and when? What does that evidence establish? What remains an inference? What is the strongest alternative explanation?

Allow the LDS explanation its actual strength. A later report is not automatically false; several retellings by one person are not several independent witnesses to the event. A difference between accounts may need explanation without proving deliberate deception. A gap in a record does not disclose a person's private motive.

If your friend supplies a stronger source or identifies an error, check it and revise your statement. Do not turn the twelve files into a rapid list of accusations. Nor should a vulnerable account from someone's family become debate material without regard for privacy.

A problem with a restoration claim does not independently prove Christ's resurrection or every Protestant interpretation. Return to the positive Christian case, and accept questions about it. Consistency in how you examine evidence matters more than scoring a quick point.

Practice the conversation

The following exchanges are illustrative examples, not quotations from real people or predictions of how an LDS person will answer.

A friend discussing grace

Friend: “You keep talking about grace, but we believe in grace too.”

Christian: “You are right to correct that impression. I should not suggest otherwise. Could you explain how grace and obedience relate to being accepted by God?”

Friend: “We need Christ. We also need to keep our covenants and endure.”

Christian: “So you are not saying you can save yourself without Christ. You see continuing covenant faithfulness as necessary. Is that a fair summary?”

Friend: “Yes.”

Christian: “The difference I want to explore is what our acceptance rests on. I understand justification as a gift received through faith, with obedience growing from that relationship. Could we read Ephesians 2:1–10 and Romans 4 and look at why we understand them differently?”

The exchange ends with a shared task, not an assumed conversion. The Christian has corrected a caricature while stating a real conviction.

Missionaries discussing authority

Missionary: “You can know the restoration is true through prayer.”

Christian: “I am willing to pray for wisdom. I also want us to consider how claims are tested. Could we agree on one claim and examine the earliest source together?”

Missionary: “Which claim do you mean?”

Christian: “We could look at the First Vision accounts, if that is a subject you want to discuss. I would like to hear your explanation of their differences as well as share the questions I have. I would also welcome your questions about the evidence for Jesus' resurrection.”

This invitation does not require the missionaries to know every historical detail immediately. Offer time to read and return. If they prefer to end the discussion, let the meeting end courteously.

A family conversation that needs to pause

Relative: “It sounds as if you think our whole family is foolish.”

Christian: “I can see why this has become painful. I do not think you are foolish. I have been pushing several points without listening. I am sorry for that. Would you rather stop?”

Relative: “Yes, for now.”

Christian: “Then we will stop. I love you. Our relationship matters to me whether or not we revisit this.”

Stopping is a faithful response to the person's stated boundary. It gives your assurance of care something concrete behind it.

Invite a response and follow through

After listening and explaining, offer a clear invitation: “Would you like to keep reading about Jesus with me? Is there anything preventing you from placing your trust in Him?” Give the person room to describe a question, disagree, ask for time, or decline.

If someone wants to trust Christ, explain repentance and faith plainly. Invite them to turn to God and rely on Christ's saving work. They may express that trust in prayer in their own words. A repeated formula does not itself establish conversion. Read the promises of the gospel together, discuss the questions that remain, and help them connect with a trustworthy Christian congregation or pastor if they want that support. [8, 9, 11]

Ask before praying together, sharing their story, arranging a meeting, or giving someone else their contact details. Offer practical friendship as they consider the implications for family and community. Do not make a major life decision sound effortless.

For continued reading, these four conversations keep the focus manageable:

1. **Who is Jesus?** Read John 1:1–18 and Colossians 1:15–20. Each person explains how the text supports their understanding.
2. **What does grace do?** Read Ephesians 2:1–10 and Titus 3:3–7. Distinguish God's action, faith, and the resulting life.

3. **How do faith and works relate?** Read Romans 4:1–8 and James 2:14–26. Address the questions each passage is answering.
4. **What grounds Christian hope?** Read 1 Corinthians 15:1–8 and Romans 5:1–11. Discuss the resurrection claim and reconciliation with God.

Agree on one next step rather than leaving an indefinite promise. If you owe a source or correction, provide it. If no further religious conversation is wanted, honor that decision.

Practice with a Christian friend or small group

Take turns explaining a belief, reflecting it back, and asking one clarifying question. The listener should be able to summarize the view accurately before responding. Use the illustrative exchanges to practice an actual correction or a respectful pause, not just a polished answer.

Afterward ask: Did we explain Christ's work clearly? Did we distinguish LDS teaching from the individual's understanding? Did we read context? Did we admit what we did not know? Was the other person free to disagree or stop? These are useful measures of faithfulness even when the outcome is uncertain.

First Corinthians 3:5–9 describes servants who plant and water while God gives the increase. Christians can prepare, speak, and love; they do not control another person's response. A fitting prayer is: “Lord, help me understand before I answer, speak truthfully about Jesus, correct my errors, and love this person patiently.”

Sources and reading

Biblical quotations are KJV; the theological explanations identify this guide's evangelical and Trinitarian perspective. Official LDS sources establish the Church's stated teachings, not the truth of every historical or theological claim. Links were checked November 8, 2026. The conversations are original illustrations.

[1] Christian manner: 1 Peter 3:13–17 and Colossians 4:2–6. Read the instruction to explain Christian hope alongside gentleness, a good conscience, prayer, and gracious speech. Read 1 Peter 3. Read Colossians 4.

[2] Patience in disagreement: 2 Timothy 2:22–26. The paragraph places correction within gentleness and dependence on God's work. Read the chapter.

[3] The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, “Are Mormons Christian?” Gospel Topics Essays. Primary institutional self-description of Christian identity, the Godhead, creeds, and additional scripture. Open source.

[4] The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, “Grace,” Gospel Study Guide. Used here for its affirmation of unearned grace and its description of faith, repentance, ordinances, and obedience. Open source.

[5] The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, “Salvation,” Gospel Topics, Overview. Distinguishes several meanings of salvation, including resurrection, salvation from sin, and exaltation. Open source.

[6] Articles of Faith 1:3–5, 8–9. Primary LDS statements about Christ's atonement, gospel principles and ordinances, authority, scripture, and revelation. Read source.

[7] Jesus and creation: John 1:1–18; Colossians 1:15–20; compare Matthew 28:19 and John 17 when discussing the Trinity. Interpret the terms within each author's argument. Read John 1. Read Colossians 1.

[8] Grace and the resulting life: Ephesians 2:1–10; Titus 3:3–7. The guide's account of salvation and works is an evangelical interpretation of these passages. Read Ephesians 2. Read Titus 3.

[9] Justification, faith, and peace with God: Romans 3:21–31; 4:1–8; 5:1–11. Read Romans 3. Read Romans 4. Read Romans 5.

[10] Living faith and works: James 2:14–26. Compare the surrounding argument with Paul's discussion rather than suppressing either text. Read James 2.

[11] The gospel and resurrection testimony: 1 Corinthians 15:1–8. Read the wider chapter for Paul's argument about the resurrection. Read the chapter.

[12] Testing claims: Acts 17:10–12; Galatians 1:6–9; 1 John 4:1–6. These texts address different settings; they should not be collapsed into a claim that every feeling proves or disproves a religion. Read Acts 17. Read Galatians 1. Read 1 John 4.

[13] Baptism and new life: Acts 2:37–41; Romans 6:1–14; compare 1 Peter 3:18–22. The guide acknowledges Christian disagreements about baptism and invites contextual examination. Read Acts 2. Read Romans 6.

[14] The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, “How Adults Can Share the Gospel,” Ways to Love, Share, and Invite. Used for its advice to listen, care, and offer invitations. Open source.

[15] The Belief Files, 00 introduction and Cases 001–012. Each investigation identifies sources, findings, competing explanations, and research limits. Consult the original records cited there for a historical discussion. Open the collection. Website collection and Case 001.